

Kanchi Kailasanatha Temple

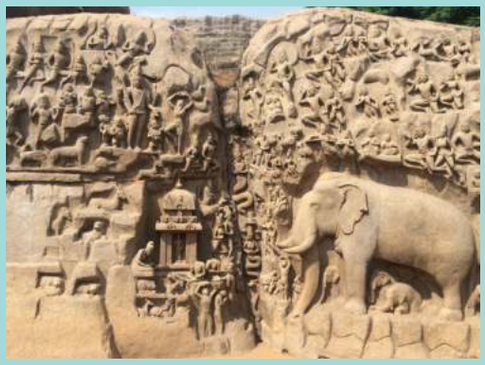


Kanchi Vaikuntha Perumal Temple

On either side are two *dwarapalas* (gatekeepers). This cave architecture reached its decadent phase after AD (CE) 700 and gave way to the large structural temples probably because the structural temples provided a wider scope to the sculptor to use his skill.

The Shore Temple at Mahabalipuram, also called the Seven Pagodas, was built by the Pallava king Narasimhavarman II. It is the oldest structural temple in South India. The structural temples were built using blocks of rock instead of a whole block as earlier. Narasimhavarman II, also known as Rajasimha, built the Kanchi Kailasanatha temple. The Vaikuntha Perumal temple at Kanchipuram was built by Nandivarman II. Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram) is built of cut stones rather than carved out of caves. It has two shrines, one dedicated to Siva and the other to Vishnu.

The Tamil Dravida tradition is exemplified by rock-cut monuments such as *Pancha Pandava Rathas*, namely Draupadi ratha, Dharmaraja ratha, Bheema ratha, Arjuna ratha and Nagula-Sahadeva ratha. The outer walls of the rathas, especially of Arjuna, Bhima and Dharmaraja, are decorated with niches and motifs. The niches have the sculptures of gods, goddesses, monarchs and scenes from mythology. The *Arjuna's Penance,* carved on the face of a granite boulder, is a magnificent relief, measuring approximately 100 ft long by 45 ft high.



Arjuna's Penance

The Mamallapuram monuments and temples, including the Shore Temple complex, were notified as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1984.

Pandya Temples in the Pallava Epoch

Early Pandyas were the contemporaries of the Pallavas. Unlike the Pallavas, Pandyas installed deities in the sanctums in their cave temples. More than fifty cave temples